Product teardown: cnftkt (train booking app)

What works, what's broken, and what I'd fix first. Owner: Rahul | Status: Draft v1.1

Note on evidence: Everything below comes from my own use of the app for 2 to 3 years and conversations with friends, family and relatives. It is not survey data yet. I will test it in 5 user interviews. Screenshots still to attach: the booking flow, the refund question for a waitlisted ticket, the first screen with ads, and the locked-coupon screen.

1. Who uses it and why

Who: People who book train tickets, many of them students and young travellers who book 20 to 30 days before the journey. cnftkt also covers flights, buses and hotels.

Why they choose it: (1) Strong brand visibility. (2) An easy, interactive interface, simpler than competitors whose interfaces are more complicated. (3) The alternate travel plan for waitlisted tickets.

How it makes money: My observation, not confirmed with the company. Advertisements on the first screen likely bring revenue. I have not checked other sources, such as booking or convenience fees, or whether wallet balances and coupon use create revenue. To verify in research.

2. The main flow (train booking)

1. Open the app and choose what to book: bus, train, flight or hotel.
2. Enter source, destination, travel date and class.
3. See the trains running on that date, with ticket availability.
4. Choose a train and class.
5. See the alternate plan, if one is offered for that train and class. The user can adopt it after entering passenger details.
6. Enter passenger details and personal information.
7. Pay with UPI, debit or credit card, wallet or other options.
8. Enter the IRCTC password on the page the app redirects to.
9. Booking is confirmed or waitlisted.
10. If waitlisted, the app asks where a refund should go (wallet or original payment source) and the choice is locked. If confirmed, the choice appears only when the user cancels.

Not confirmed: whether users get confused at the IRCTC password step. To check in interviews.

3. What works well

- **The alternate travel plan.** If a waitlisted ticket doesn't confirm, the user gets a refund plus a coupon (2x, 3x or 4x, as shown at booking) instead of being left with nothing.
- **Easy, interactive interface.** Simple steps from search to ticket keep users from giving up, which matters for people booking with little time or patience.
- **Showing the chances of confirmation.** For a waitlisted ticket, users can decide with real information instead of guessing.

Pattern: All three strengths help users before the journey is settled. The app is strong at helping users book and weaker at helping them after something goes wrong.

4. What's broken

- **Few people know about the alternate plan.** The app's best feature is not widely known. Evidence: my observation from conversations.
- **The refund choice for waitlisted tickets.** It is asked right after booking, usually about 30 days before travel, and cannot be changed. A ticket cancelled just before travel can mean waiting up to 7 working days for money needed now. Evidence: it happened to me and one friend (about ₹2,700, cancelled 8 hours before travel).
- **The first screen is mostly advertisements.** Users have to hunt for the features they came for. Ads likely bring revenue, so the fix is to give the main features space too, not to remove ads. Evidence: my own use.
- **The coupon stays locked until the original train departs.** Users can claim the coupon but cannot use it for a new flight, train or bus booking until the train leaves the boarding station. The terms and conditions do not mention this. Evidence: I faced it on 26 Oct 2026, and friends and relatives reported it too.

5. What I'd fix first

I scored each problem from 1 to 5 (higher is better). These scores are my estimates and the interviews will test them.

Problem	People affected	How much it hurts	Easy to fix	Total
1. Low awareness of the alternate plan	4	3	3	10
2. Refund choice locked at booking	**4**	**4**	**5**	**13**
3. Ads on the first screen	5	2	4	11
4. Locked coupon	3	4	3	10

Decision: fix problem 2, the refund choice, first. It hurts users at the worst moment, when a ticket is cancelled just before travel and they need money to rebook. It is also the easiest to fix, because the wallet already exists and is instant, so the change is mostly a choice screen shown after cancellation. The locked coupon comes next, once we understand why the rule exists. The full solution is written up in PRD v1.